



THE NATIONAL Park Service says operating the Colosseum Mine gives federal officials little ability to minimize environmental damage.

At odds over an old Mojave gold mine

National Park Service battles Australian firm over extraction of rare earth minerals.

By ALEX WIGGLESWORTH

MOJAVE NATIONAL PRESERVE, Calif. — Deep in the Mojave National Preserve lies an old open pit mine where workers dug and drilled for gold and silver from the late 1800s to the 1990s. Miners are back at the Colosseum Mine today — but now they’re also looking for rare earth minerals used

in advanced technologies.

The National Park Service is trying to stop it — at least until the agency can review and sign off on the activities. It claims that the mining company, Australia’s Dateline Resources Ltd., is operating the Colosseum Mine without authorization, giving federal officials little ability to minimize environmental damage in an area ecologists say is rich with rare plants.

The mining company says it has the right to work the mine under a plan its previous operators submitted to the Bureau of Land Management more than 40

years ago.

Several elected officials are backing the company against the Park Service, pointing to the national security importance of developing America’s capacity to produce rare earth minerals, which are used in smartphones, advanced weapons and electric vehicles. China dominates the market.

“Any discussion of the mine should start with its importance to national security due to its potential to contain rare earth materials,” San Bernardino County Supervisor Paul Cook said in an email. “To my knowl- [See Odds, A8]



THE MINE sits near California’s border with Nevada. Gold was first discovered there in the late 1860s.

Bird flu experts looking beyond culling

Killing poultry by the millions hasn’t kept H5N1 in check. Is there a better way?

By SUSANNE RUST AND KAREN KAPLAN

When the deadly H5N1 bird flu virus made its first appearance at a U.S. poultry farm in February 2022, roughly 29,000 turkeys at an Indiana facility were sacrificed in an attempt to avert a larger outbreak.

It didn’t work. Three years later, highly pathogenic avian influenza, or HPAI, has spread to all 50 states. The number of commercial birds that have died or been killed exceeds 166 million and the price of eggs is at an all-time high.

Poultry producers, infectious disease experts and government officials now concede that H5N1 is probably here to stay. That recognition is prompting some of them to question whether the long-standing practice of culling every single bird on an infected farm is sustainable over the long term.

Instead, they are discussing such strategies as targeted depopulation, vaccinations and even the relocation of wetlands and bodies of water to lure virus-carrying wild birds away from poultry farms.

But each of these alternatives [See Bird flu, A6]

Most on the streets not using drugs, study says

By DOUG SMITH

A large majority of people living on the streets in California are not illegal drug users, a study found. But drug use is still deeply intertwined with homelessness, both as a risk factor and an effect of losing housing, the researchers wrote.

The study, published in the medical journal JAMA by the Benioff Homeless and Housing Initiative at UC San Francisco, gives a complex statistical picture of a topic that has been fraught with conflicting narratives. Against a public perception that drug use is endemic to homeless camps, service providers and advocates see an exaggerated reaction to open drug use on the street that stigmatizes the majority of homeless people who do not use drugs.

The Benioff study supports some elements of both viewpoints. Contrary to common perception, only about 37% of homeless people were using illicit drugs regularly, and 25% said they had never used drugs. But drug use is far more prevalent among homeless people than in the general population. Just over 65% reported [See Homelessness, A10]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

DRAWN TO DARKNESS

Having made his mark in such roles as a sadistic western sheriff in “Unforgiven,” Hackman told The Times he was intrigued by disturbed characters.

GENE HACKMAN, 1930 - 2025

A two-time Oscar winner and prolific Hollywood star

After a breakout role in ‘Bonnie and Clyde,’ he appeared in nearly 80 films in long career.

By DENNIS McLELLAN

Gene Hackman, the Oscar-winning actor who brought a flinty menace to films such as “Bonnie and Clyde,” “The French Connection” and “Unforgiven,” was found dead Wednesday along with

his wife in New Mexico, authorities said. He was 95.

The Santa Fe County Sheriff’s Department said Hackman, his wife, Betsy Arakawa, 64, and their dog were found in their home and an investigation is underway.

Over his long career, Hackman won Academy Awards for portrayals of an obsessed undercover narcotics cop in “The French Connection” and a sadistic western sheriff in “Unforgiven.” He came to fame on the big screen in “Bonnie and Clyde,” the landmark

1967 movie starring Warren Beatty and Faye Dunaway as the notorious Depression-era bank robbers. His supporting role as Buck Barrow, Clyde’s good-old-boy brother, earned Hackman his first Oscar nomination.

“Because of ‘Bonnie and Clyde,’ ” Hackman told The Times in 1968, “quite a few people come up to me, and I’m not the kind of person you come up to — I look so common.”

A 6-foot-2 ex-Marine and barroom brawler with a face [See Hackman, A10]

COLUMN ONE

After fire, a piece of film history endures

Moviemaker lost his home, but his ‘Forrest Gump’ bench still stands

By Chris Erskine

Good homes have good souls, just as beloved movies do. Rick Carter knows both. On Jan. 7, the renowned production designer — for “Jurassic Park,” “Avatar” and more — had just settled in for the night with half an Ambien and his wife, Adele, when a concerned friend called their Paris hotel. A raging wildfire was threatening the Carters’ Pacific Palisades home, she said.

At stake: the three-bedroom house where the Carters had raised their two kids, wiped their noses, helped with history homework, prepped for proms, while he designed \$12 billion worth of blockbusters.

Modest by Hollywood standards, the handsome little home also contained a treasure trove of Carter’s own paintings and sketches, 1,000 pieces in all, as well as his most mystical keepsake: a bench.

Not just any bench, of course, just as the legendary Carter isn’t just any moviemaker.

For, in Carter’s backyard, [See Bench, A6]

Students reel under Utah’s DEI ban

Black, Asian, other groups say they no longer feel valued at the state’s flagship university. **NATION, A5**

The Trump effect on public health

Barbara Ferrer discusses the challenges at her L.A. County department. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Partly sunny. L.A. Basin: 68/51. **B6**

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Mattel regains rights for DC

Deal could fuel more toy sales and boost competition with rivals such as Hasbro. **BUSINESS, A7**

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